

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

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INTRODUCTION

We are about to begin one of the central portions of the Yom Kippur davening, called the *Seder Avodah*, the order of the Yom Kippur service that took place in the *Bais Hamikdash*, the Holy Temple in Yerushalayim on the day of Yom Kippur.

It was this service which brought about the actualization of the Atonement of Yom Kippur. Our sages tell us that the very essence of the day of Yom Kippur itself – *עצומו של יום* – is what atones. What enables us to connect to this level of *עצומו של יום*, the essence of the day, is the service in the *Bais Hamikdash*—the Yom Kippur service is what brings this lofty level of atonement into actuality.

But presently we are in exile. For over 1900 years the Jewish people has been without a *Bais Hamikdash* in which to do this service. What we have in its place is davening: our prayers and *tshuva* are our *avodah*, our service in the absence of a *Bais Hamikdash*. Together with this we recite the *Seder Avodah* as it occurred in the Holy Temple on the day of Yom Kippur, and this is considered as if it were in fact occurring now, and through this we make the connection to the “essence of the day”, the lofty level of Yom Kippur which brings atonement.

THE PRIESTLY VESTMENTS

The Kohanim were and are descendants of Aharon Hakohen, the brother of Moshe Rabbeinu (Moses our teacher) and his sons who were selected by Hashem to serve as the Priests. The *Seder Avodah* describes the special *Bigdei Kahuna*, the priestly garments, which are actually 8 garments:

1. A gold forehead-plate, called the *tzitz*;
2. A robe, called the *me'il*;
3. A breastplate, called the *choshen*;
4. An *ephod*, which covers the lower part of the body from behind, like a reverse apron;
5. A tunic, called the *k'sones*;
6. Linen breeches, called *Michnasei Baad*;
7. A turban, called the *mitznefes*;
8. And a belt, called the *avnet*;

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

These are 8 garments, which include the 4 regular linen garments of an ordinary Kohen, and the 4 special garments of the Kohen Gadol, which contained gold. Part of the Yom Kippur service is performed by the Kohen Gadol wearing all 8 garments, and later, when he requests atonement for Israel, he changes into a set of 4 linen garments made especially for Yom Kippur, and worn only one time. After this they were put away forever. We will see that the Kohen Gadol changes his garments several times, and each time he does so he first immerses in the Mikvah.

It says in our *machzor* that when he was robed in the prescribed number of linen garments and golden vestments, beset with precious stones, the Kohen Gadol, the High Priest, appeared like the *malach Michael*, the ministering angel. It is through the Kohen Gadol performing this service that Israel is granted pardon for iniquity.

PREPARATION THE WEEK BEFORE YOM KIPPUR

Beginning seven days before Yom Kippur, which means right after Rosh Hashanah, the Kohen Gadol studies the laws of how to perform the *Avodah*. This is because the *Avodah* is like almost everything else in Judaism: the loftiest spiritual accomplishments are achieved through lowly physical actions, and these physical actions must be performed correctly in order to bring about the desired results in the spiritual realms. This is true today, whether it is putting on Tefillin in the proper spot on the head and the arm, or lighting Shabbos candles at the proper time before sunset, or making the appropriate blessing on a particular food—the power of a Jew to create tremendous spiritual impact is dependent on the Jew performing the physical mitzvah properly. And this was very much the case on Yom Kippur with the service of the Kohen Gadol, the High Priest, and so he had to make sure that he knew exactly what he had to do and to be practiced in the actions so that he would be able to perform them properly.

On the 3rd and 7th day of the week preceding Yom Kippur he is sprinkled with the purifying waters of the *Para Adumah*, the Red Heifer, to make sure that he will be ritually pure for the service on Yom Kippur. The scholars and the learned Kohanim would surround him until the day of Yom Kippur arrives, and they say to him: “See before Whom you are entering, into a place of blazing, flaming fire; the congregation of our people depend on you, for through you comes our pardon.” No one entered the Holy of Holies except for the Kohen Gadol on Yom Kippur—the holiest man entering the holiest place on the holiest day of the year. He had to be completely righteous to survive this level of Divine revelation.

IMMERSION

When the day of Yom Kippur arrives, the first thing that occurs is that the Kohen Gadol immerses in a kosher mikvah for purification and sanctification. This is the same mikvah that

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

Jewish men and women immerse in today, the “living waters” that remove spiritual impurity and grant additional levels of holiness.

The other Kohanim, the other priests, hold a linen sheet around him as a partition so that he is concealed from the people while he disrobes and examines his body for anything that could interpose between his body and the water of the mikvah. He removes his weekday garments, descends to the mikvah, immerses, comes back up and dries himself. Then he is given the garments of gold to wear, which were made with threads that had actually strands of gold woven into them and these are the special garments of the High Priest. He sanctifies himself by washing his hands and feet from a golden pitcher.

KEVES HATAMID--DAILY BURNT OFFERING

Immediately he receives the lamb for the daily burnt-offering, called the *Tamid*. Using a kosher slaughter knife he cuts through the majority of throat, and leaves it for another Kohen to finish the job. He receives the blood from the animal in a vessel and sprinkles it on the altar, which is something that was done every day, although not necessarily by the High Priest—even an ordinary Priest could do it. However, on Yom Kippur even this “every-day” offering is performed by the High Priest because it reflects how the day of Yom Kippur elevates even those things which are not unique to Yom Kippur.

The same thing applies to the next task he performs, which is to enter the *Heichal*, which is the two-story structure of the Holy Temple complex, to clean 5 of the 7 cups of the gold menorah and to offer the morning *ketores*, incense offering, followed by cleaning the remaining 2 cups of the menorah. He comes out and offers the head and the parts of the daily burnt-offering in the usual way. As on any other day he brings an offering of *chavitin*, a kind of pancake, and the wine libation accompanied by various musical instruments played by the Levites.

INSIGHT: Chassidic teachings explain that the difference between the job of the Kohanim and the Leviim, the Priests and the Levites, is due to the difference in the source of their souls. The source of the souls of the Kohanim is connected with the flow from above to below, like water, and so they were capable of drawing G-d’s blessings from Above down into the world, like the wine libation that they poured on the Altar which was connected with drawing down spiritual beneficence down into the world. The source of the souls of the Leviim, the Levites, is connected to the flow from below to above, like fire, and so they had the job of playing music during the offerings, which represents the elevation of the spiritual dimension of the animals that are being physically consumed as sacrifices, the elevation from below to above.

After the daily burnt offering, the High Priest offers the bull of the burnt-offering and the 7 lambs of the additional *musaf* offerings of the Day, each with their meal-offering and libation.

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

If Yom Kippur was on Shabbos he first offers the Shabbos offerings and arranges the showbread.

Immediately after this he goes again to the mikveh. His fellow Kohanim spread out the linen sheet between him and the people and he sanctifies himself by washing his hands and feet, removing his golden vestments, descending to the mikveh and immersing for the 2nd time. Then he comes up and dries himself. This time he puts on the white vestments, because the special service of Yom Kippur is to be performed only in the white garments, not the gold garments. What is the reason? The simple reason is that although gold is precious, it is reminiscent of the sin of the Golden Calf, and since the service of Yom Kippur is to secure atonement there shouldn't be any reminder of sin.

He quickly sanctifies his hands and feet and proceeds to his bull, which is his personal atonement, which is standing in the northern side of the Temple Court, between the building of the Holy Temple and the Altar outside of it, with its head to the south and its face to the west; the Kohen Gadol stands in the east with his face to the west. He stands in a state of great awe before Hashem and makes confession over the bull, which means that he places his hands on the bull's head and leans on the bull while making a confession.

INSIGHT: Before we continue, many of us probably have a question: Just a moment ago we said the Kohen Gadol had to be a completely righteous; if so, then what does he have to confess?! There are several answers to this—One answer is that he is responsible for the actions of his household and his fellow Kohanim. But a deeper answer is that the meaning of the word “sin” is “falling short of what is expected”. More is expected and demanded of Tzaddikim who are completely righteous, and thus it is possible for them to be considered to have “sinned”—not because they did something evil, G-d forbid, which needs to be cleansed; but rather because they did not do everything they were capable of accomplishing. They didn't utilize their abilities to full capacity—for such Tzaddikim, this is considered a sin. And deeper yet is the concept that we find in the holy Zohar, the fundamental book of Jewish mysticism, which states that Moshiach will make even the Tzaddikim, the righteous, do *tshuva*. This is because the revelation of G-dliness that is poised to occur with the revelation of Moshiach—very soon, in our own generation—will cause everyone, even one who is perfectly righteous, to realize that Hashem is even greater than he was able to conceive of previously, and thus he will realize that all that he did previously, as perfect as it might have been, was not good enough. Thus, he will repent over his previous Divine service which appears insufficient in light of the lofty Divine revelations that Moshiach brings. Thus, even one who is sinless has what to confess!

Returning to the service of the Kohen Gadol offering his confession over his bull, this is what he would say (bottom of page 179):

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

O G-d, I have sinned, I have committed iniquity, I have transgressed before You, I and my household. I beseech You, for the sake of Your ineffable Name, grant atonement for the sins, iniquities and transgressions which I have sinned, committed and transgressed before You, I and my household, as it is written in the Torah of Moses Your servant in Your glorious Name: For on this day atonement shall be made for you, to purify you of all your sins before Hashem...

And when the Kohanim and the people standing in the Temple Court heard the glorious and awesome Name fully pronounced issuing from the mouth of the Kohen Gadol in holiness and purity, they would bend their knees, bow down and fall on their faces and exclaim: *Baruch shem kavod malchuso l'olam vo'ed* (Blessed be the name of the glory of His kingdom forever and ever).

This confession is repeated three times: once for the Kohen Gadol himself; once for all the Kohanim; and once for all of Israel. You will notice that in the confession, we use the word Hashem twice and finish off with G-d's name. In the *Bais Hamikdash*, the High Priest actually said G-d's name as it is written *YH-VH*, which is not the way we normally say it: "*Ado-nay*". This is why we refer to it as the "ineffable name" for outside of the Holy Temple we never pronounce it as it is written. When the Jews that were in the *Bais HaMikdash* and on the Plaza area of the Temple Mount, heard the High Priest pronounce G-d's name, it was so awe-inspiring they would fall down and prostrate themselves and say *Boruch shem kavod*.

INSIGHT: It is also worth noting the choice of language used here. The Kohen Gadol in this confession quotes from the Torah "For on this day atonement shall be made for you, to purify you of all your sins before Hashem ...", which in Hebrew is:

כִּי-בְיוֹם הַזֶּה יִכָּפֵר עֲלֵיכֶם, לְטַהֵר אֶתְכֶם: מִכָּל, חַטֹּאתֵיכֶם, לִפְנֵי יְהוָה, תִּטְהָרוּ.

It is explained in Chassidus that there is a lot of meaning in the expression "לִפְנֵי יְהוָה, תִּטְהָרוּ" – "before Hashem [you shall be purified]." The connection between Yom Kippur and the verse "before Hashem [you shall be purified]" is as follows: according to the teachings of Kabbalah, when one sins one causes a blemish in one of the letters of Hashem's Divine name of *YK-VK*. Since the mitzvos, the commandments, are mitzvos of Hashem—mitzvos of *YK-VK*—they are unable to rectify a blemish in Hashem's name. But because the day of Yom Kippur is so exceedingly lofty and holy, it lifts us to a level of G-dliness that is "before Hashem", meaning higher than the name *YK-VK*; and from this exalted level it becomes possible to rectify any blemish that we have caused by our actions in the past. Thus it is specifically on Yom Kippur, when we stand "before Hashem", higher than *YK-VK*, that we are able to be purified of any and all misdeeds. And this is true even for us today—here and now.

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

THE LOTTERY

Now we encounter the lottery to select the famous “scapegoat”, something unique to the Yom Kippur service.

The Kohen Gadol proceeds to the east of the Temple, north of the altar, together with the assistant High Priest, called the *S’gan*, on his right and the head of the group of priests serving that week in the Temple on his left. Two male goats—completely identical—are standing there facing the west with their backs to the east, one to his right and one to his left. In the middle was a box that contains two lots made of wood and in later years made of gold. On one is inscribed “La’Hashem”—for Hashem, an offering for Hashem—and on the other is inscribed “Le’Azazel”—“for Azazel”, to be sent away to the wilderness. What is the meaning of this Azazel, will be touched on shortly. The Kohen Gadol then shakes the box and quickly removes the two lots, one in his right hand and one in his left hand. If the lot that comes up in his right hand has the Divine Name inscribed on it, he places it on the goat and says: “A sin-offering to Hashem.”

Pronouncing the glorious and awesome name of Hashem, in holiness and purity, causes all the people to bend their knees, bow down, and fall on their faces and exclaim again *Baruch shem kavod malchuso l’olam vo’ed* (Blessed be the name of the glory of His kingdom forever and ever).

Next, the Kohen Gadol binds a scarlet band, a red band, between the horns of the other goat, the one not selected for Hashem. This is the goat that is to be sent to Azazel, and it is placed at the eastern gate from where it will be led to the wilderness. On the goat that is for Hashem, the Kohen Gadol ties a scarlet band on its throat where it will be slaughtered. He goes again to his bull and confesses over it a second time for his household and his fellow Kohanim, as we described previously, with all the Jews present falling on their faces in awe at the pronouncement of the ineffable name.

ENTERING THE HOLY OF HOLIES

Upon completing the confession the Kohen Gadol quickly examines the slaughtering knife and proceeds to slaughter the bull, with the slaughter being completed by one of the other Kohanim. He collects the blood in a new bowl and gives it to one of his fellow Kohanim to stir it so that the blood will not congeal before the time comes to sprinkle it upon the altar. It is important to recognize that all of these physical actions are of great spiritual significance, and thus the great care that is taken to insure that they are done exactly as prescribed.

The High Priest now takes a pan, fills it with coals from the altar, takes a ladle filled with incense and prepares to enter the Holy of Holies for the first time. He walks through the Holy, then

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

between the two curtains that separate the Holy from the Holy of Holies. He comes before the *Aron Hakodesh*, the Holy Ark, places down the pan with coals and carefully sprinkles the incense on the coals. He walks out backwards until he is on the other side of the curtain and offers a short prayer. The prayer is short, as no one was in the Holy when he entered the Holy of Holies, and everyone is concerned that he should emerge unscathed from his service, so he would say a short prayer so as not to take too much time before he exits the building.

The following was the prayer of the Kohen Gadol (page 182):

May it be Your will, Hashem our G-d and G-d of our fathers, that this coming year shall be for us and for all Your people, the House of Israel, wherever they are, rich in rain if it is hot. And when the world is in need of rain, do not permit the prayers of travelers with regard to rain to gain entrance before You. May Your people, the House of Israel, not be dependent for their livelihood upon one another nor upon any other people. May it be a year that no woman suffer miscarriage, that the trees of the field yield their produce, and may there not depart a ruler from the House of Judah.

He then goes out takes the blood of the bull from the person who was mixing it and enters the Holy of Holies for the second time. He stands in front of the Ark and sprinkles the blood eight times, once upwards and seven times downwards. He would not sprinkle in a pointing manner using the thumb and index finger, rather he would be moving his hand in an upwards motion or in a downwards motion. In order to make sure that he didn't make a mistake by counting one as he sprinkles upwards and then counting two when he would sprinkle downwards and thus miss out on the first time sprinkling downwards, he would count one as he sprinkles upwards and count one and one, one and two, one and three etc. as he is sprinkling downwards.

This is the counting that we recite together four times—*Achas. Achas v'achas. Achas v'shtayim*. This is the counting of the Kohen Gadol as he sprinkles the blood.

The Kohen Gadol then slaughters the goat designated for G-d, takes the blood, reenters the Holy of Holies and again sprinkles eight times, once upwards, seven times downwards. He counts again, *Achas. Achas v'achas. Achas v'shtayim, etc.*

He again takes the blood of the bull, stands outside the curtains separating the Holies and the Holy of Holies and again sprinkles eight times, once upwards, seven times downwards. He counts again, *Achas. Achas v'achas. Achas v'shtayim, etc.*

He again takes the blood of the goat and does the same, standing outside the curtains separating the Holies and the Holy of Holies and again sprinkles eight times, once upwards, seven times downwards. He counts again, *Achas. Achas v'achas. Achas v'shtayim, etc.*

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

He then mixes the bloods together and sprinkles them on the smaller inside Altar that was normally only used to burn incense. He sprinkles on the four corners of the Altar and seven times on the center.

THE SCAPEGOAT—TO AZAZEL

Now the Kohen Gadol exits the Holy of Holies, exits the *Heichal*, and comes to the goat that has been designated to be sent to Azazel. Over this goat he makes a confession for the guilt of his congregation, meaning all of Israel. He places his two hands between its horns and confesses. This is what he would say (page 184):

Oh G-d, Your people, the House of Israel, have sinned, have committed iniquity and have transgressed before You. I beseech You, for the sake of Your ineffable Name, grant atonement for the sins, iniquities and transgressions which Your people, the House of Israel, have sinned, committed and transgressed, as it is written in the Torah of Moses Your servant in Your glorious Name: For on this day, atonement shall be made for you, to purify you of all your sins before Hashem.

As before, the Kohen Gadol pronouncing the glorious and awesome name of Hashem, in holiness and purity, causes all the people to bend their knees, bow down, and fall on their faces and exclaim again *Baruch shem kavod malchuso l'olam vo'ed* (Blessed be the name of the glory of His kingdom forever and ever).

The Kohen Gadol aimed to complete his utterance of the Divine Name simultaneously with those reciting Baruch Shem, ending with the words “You shall be cleansed”. And Hashem’s compassion would be aroused, and He would pardon the congregation of *Yeshurun*, meaning the Jewish people.

At this point the Kohen Gadol summons a Kohen who had been designated the previous day to be the one to lead away the scapegoat. He hands over the goat to this man, who leads it to an uninhabited land, a desolate wilderness. When he reaches the top of a cliff he divides the scarlet band and ties one half to the rock and the other half between its horns, and with his two hands he pushes it backwards. It goes rolling down and before it reaches halfway it is dashed to pieces. The Kohen says “Thus may the sins of Your people, the House of Israel, be wiped away.” The forgiveness of the sins of Israel would be evident by the scarlet band tied to its horns turning white.

INSIGHT: To explain the mysterious commandment of sending away the goat to Azazel, we can turn to the medieval Jewish commentators **Avraham ibn Ezra** and the **Ramban** (known as **Nachmanides**), who explain that the *Azazel* goat was actually a bribe to the forces of evil.

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

As explained at length in Kabbalah and Chassidus, there are forces in the world that were created by Hashem to challenge us by concealing Hashem's presence in the world. We call them "evil"—which they are! But they, like everything else created by Hashem, only do what they are commanded. Their job is to tempt us and then punish us; our job is to resist their temptation and eliminate them. These forces receive additional "nourishment" and energy when one succumbs to sin. When one repents and does *tshuva*, one of the chief objectives is to reclaim the energy from which the forces of darkness suckled during the performance of the sin. But these forces don't part with their sustenance so easily. They plead their case before the Heavenly Court, claiming that they "earned" their spoils.

Therefore, Hashem instructs the Jewish people to send off a goat to "the prosecutor" on the day of Yom Kippur. A bribe, mimicking the sacrifices brought by the idol worshippers, to ensure that when they are called upon to testify, they will only speak well of the Jewish nation. This should not be confused with offering sacrifices to them, G-d forbid, which is why the goat is referred to as being "sent off" to the "other side".

And even this very precept we observe—not out of fear of the Satan, for we fear only the One G-d—but because this is what G-d, in His infinite wisdom, commanded us to do. (*source: www.AskMoses.com*)

Following the sending of the scapegoat, the Kohen burns parts of the bull and the goat for Hashem on the altar. When the scapegoat reaches the wilderness, the Kohen Gadol returns to the Women's courtyard to read passages from the Torah. He proceeds then to immerse in the mikveh a 3rd time, removing his white garments and dressing in the gold garments. Then he offers his own ram and the ram of the people, along with their meal offerings and wine offerings and then the evening daily-offering. He then goes again to immerse in the mikvah for the 4th time, dressing this time in the white vestments, which he is dressed in when he enters the Holy of Holies. He re-enters the Holy of Holies to retrieve the ladle and firepan which were placed there earlier. Following this he goes to the mikvah now for the 5th time, and dresses again in the gold vestments.

INSIGHT: One of the reasons for the five immersions is that every immersion in them mikvah is connected with an elevation in holiness. The soul is described as having five levels, and each time the Kohen immersed in the waters of the mikveh he is revealing a higher level of holiness corresponding to a higher level of his soul. This is also the reason why Yom Kippur is the only day that we offer 5 prayers. During the week we offer 3 prayers—evening, morning, and afternoon. On Shabbos and holidays we offer 4 prayers, with the additional *musaf* prayer. Only on Yom Kippur do we offer a 5th prayer, the *Neilah* service with which we end the day. And it is during that 5th prayer service of *Neilah* that the 5th and highest level of the soul becomes revealed, something which only occurs on Yom Kippur.

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

After his final immersion, the Kohen Gadol burns the afternoon incense offering, lights the menorah, like every other day, and makes the rest of the offerings. Then he removes his Golden vestments and gets dressed in his own clothes and returns to his home accompanied by all the people. He celebrates this as a personal Yom Tov for having come out of the Holy of Holies in peace, and we sing the “*Mareh Kohen*” which describes the transcendent beauty of the Kohen Gadol when he came out of the Holy of Holies (page 186). Fortunate is they eye that saw all these.

If we could imagine the “spiritual high” that the people were on when they witnessed all this, actually seeing with their own eyes that Hashem has wiped away their sins, then we could begin to appreciate how much we lack because the Beis Hamikdash, the Holy Temple is not standing. Indeed this is the tone of lament we find through the end of the *Seder Avodah*—the lowly state of the Jewish people without a Holy Temple to cleanse us of our sins.

INSIGHT: The truth is that our generation doesn’t relate so easily to this expression of lamentation. And it is not just because we are insensitive, or because we are not as religious as our ancestors, or because we don’t know or don’t care. It is actually much deeper and more significant than that. The **Lubavitcher Rebbe** explains it as follows: ours is the last generation of exile, both physical and spiritual, and the first generation of the *Geulah*—the redemption. Although we ourselves don’t yet see this, our *neshomas*, our souls, *do* see this. The *neshoma* of every single Jew sees the redemption, how close we are to the 3rd *Bais Hamikdash*, the 3rd Holy Temple, which our sages tell us will descend in fire from the Heavens, fully built. And because the 3rd Temple will exceed the first two in terms of the revelation of G-dliness that it will bring, and it is eternal and never to be destroyed, this causes an excitement and anticipation in our souls that overwhelms the sense of emptiness and loss that arises from the fact that presently the Temple is not standing. So for this reason, explains the Rebbe, we don’t feel so acutely the loss of the 1st and 2nd Temples.

Although the revelations of the 3rd *Bais Hamikdash* are truly beyond anything we could possibly comprehend while living in this limited world, nonetheless they will not be completely disconnected from our present reality. This is reflected in the statement of our sages that in the future all the shuls and all the study halls in the world will be connected to the 3rd *Bais Hamikdash*. This reflects the connection between our Divine service in the present—limited though it may be—and the unlimited revelation of G-dliness that will come about through the 3rd *Bais Hamikdash*. In other words, within our limited world will be revealed the unlimited—G-dliness.

The Rebbe repeated many times that the world is now ready for this, and we ourselves are ready for this. All we have to do is “just a little more” in the way of goodness and kindness to tip the scales and Moshiach will come. Our sincere commitment, right now, to take on one

THE SEDER AVODAH OF YOM KIPPUR

more *mitzvah* is so precious in G-d's eyes that it could be enough to tip the scales of the entire world! Let each one of us make a resolution today, right now, to take on one additional *mitzvah*, to tip our personal scales and contribute to the well-being of the entire Jewish people and the entire world. Through one good resolution!

At this point we read about the *Asara Harugei Malchus*, the 10 martyrs, the ten great sages and *Tzaddikim* who were tragically put to death by the Romans in the time of the 2nd Temple, almost 2000 years ago. The translation in the *machzor* really needs no elaboration, and everyone should read along, from the middle of page 192.

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G'mar chasima tova!